

The Black American Experience

Race relations were tense in the early 1960s, even before the war drew hundreds of thousands of men of color into military service. Questions about the war reached a fever pitch as Black Americans confronted a war many deemed exploitative and imperialist.

◀ BEFORE

A century after the Civil War, Black Americans still did not enjoy equal access to education, opportunities, or franchise in the United States.

FIGHT FOR THEIR RIGHTS

Historically, Black Americans viewed military service positively, because it provided job skills and conferred respect that could result in better employment opportunities in civilian life. In World War II, Black Americans embraced a **"Double V" strategy** that supported victory abroad while also demanding race equality in the United States. However, the pace of change remained slow after the war, leading to the modern **Civil Rights Movement** of the 1950s and 1960s.

The Vietnam War was the first US conflict fought with a fully racially integrated military. However, while the Armed Forces were formally desegregated by 1954, discrimination remained, often preventing Black soldiers from rising in the ranks.

Racial tensions also continued to boil on the home front, especially as the Civil Rights Movement gained momentum. Dr. Martin Luther King Jr. remarked in 1967 that it was a cruel irony to watch Black and white men kill and die together in Vietnam, all for a nation unable to seat them together in the same room.



Honoring Dr. King

On January 15, 1971, Black American soldiers raise their fists in Black Power salutes for the birthday of the late Dr. Martin Luther King Jr. His assassination in 1968 caused some Black troops to reevaluate their participation in the war.

Changing attitudes